

## **Introduction:**

Bengal is a geographical region with its unique geography, environmental reality and demographic mixes. This has resulted in the development of a faith practices system which is also mixed and evolving more focused on response to social reality than theology or strict belief structures.

Bengal is in the midst of two cultures and civilizations. As part of a rice civilization that originates in China and stretches over SE Asia, it has received many migrations resulting in a successful rice based civilization. This makes it close to faith practices that interact with nature.

On the other end, Bengal is linked to North India from which the Aryan civilization sprang and flourished. So it has influenced Bengal but is more prominent among the ancient ruling class rather than the peasants and farmers. So Bengal is not a by-product of Aryan practice and faith but is produced by many non-Aryan influences that came in before the Aryan arrival. Aryan influence does exist but that is one of the many influences. So, like Bengal ethnicity is a mixed one, its faith practice is also mixed.

## **Factor of Faith and Practices (Geography and Faith practices):**

When Aryan culture came in contact with Bengal other cultural strands had already taken root. These cultural influences came from many sources like its ethnicity. Thus their world view was shaped by the introduction of many elements. While Aryan became the ruling class and their culture was Vedic influenced, at the social level Bengal incorporated mostly indigenous, pre-Aryan belief structures. There is no evidence that in the earlier era they were asked to adjust belief structures.

As an agricultural people, the response to the livelihood challenge articulated their belief the most. In effect, it's the faith structure of people living without any significant economic surplus and this precariousness of livelihood and life determined their beliefs. So it's the faith culture of the underclass. Since nature played a very significant role both in agriculture and migration the primary faith practices were linked to nature worship and animism. This is common in all civilizations of this sort and Bengal was no different.

To them the land, the river, the weather etc all became the sources of power which deserve worshiping in order to sustain livelihood. As a deltaic land with high rainfall which resulted in extensive food production, nature worship was inevitable. That they

co-existed with sophisticated Aryan belief structures shows how deeply rooted they were but also the capacity of such societies to pick and choose from other faith structures including the Aryans. Since its agro settlements were old but rural, contact with urban Indian centers generally run by Aryans was never high.

Bengal was outside the Aryabarta –the Aryan circle- and Pundra which was linked to North India was a frontier state, “Prottanto’ state. The Aryans initially considered people of Bengal as ***unclean people – Asura-*** but that potential for profit from agriculture and burgeoning trade attracted them a bit later. Hindu caste structure is essentially an urban articulation of the Mauryan era, so it had little in common with an overwhelmingly rural Bengal of farmers and fisherman who could only qualify as Sudra and Nomo-Sudra. So the very nature of Bengal geography and economics limited Aryan interest in matters of its people’s faith.

The frontier region of the Aryan world also saw the rise of samantas and chieftains who ruled over large areas and constituted a strong link with the Aryan heartland. However, they were not into prosecution or conversion but what we see is leakage of ideas, deities, and ultimately caste ideas through constant contact between the ruler and the ruled.

The first large-scale influence of the Aryan religion was in Hindu-Buddhism. Buddhism emerges as a byproduct of Hinduism and in protest against the elitist ritualism controlled by the Brahmins. In that era Indian faiths were not seen separately although in some cases there could be conflicts but they were more like sects of the same religion. So we find social Buddhism in a very broad sense having more influence than orthodox textual/ Rig Vedic Hinduism from the beginning as it was more welcoming going beyond the priest –worshiper relationship.

Buddhism has three major versions all of which would have been seen in Bengal. The first version is called Hinayana Buddhism which is the earliest version and very strict in practices. The second form was called Mahayana Buddhism, which was signified by the emergence of monks’ who would perform religious prayers and rituals on behalf of ordinary people. It was far more influenced by traditional Hinduism and the sight of Buddhist god and goddess showed how both were coming close. It was in some sense more people friendly. These forms grew with the rise of Buddhist Monasteries run by monks which were also owners of great land holdings. So Mahayana Buddhism is often mentioned as a land owning force as well.

The third form to emerge was Bajrayana or Tantric Buddhism which was a mix of Pre-Aryan belief and supernatural practices and animist culture. And this obviously found an easy root to develop in Bengal since these beliefs corresponded to the ideas of traditional people held by Bengal. In some sense these stages of Buddhism are symbolic of the Bengali worldview which is more practical, more divine intervention based, more about food and shelter rather than theological or other worldly matters. Subsequently, both traditional Hinduism and Buddhism came close often because of adoption of Tantric practices.

Shasanka, the so-called first independent ruler of Bengal was often referred to as anti-Buddhist. However, this is questionable since it was common to make the enemy look bad in religious terms and most of the references are found in those sources which belong to Shashanka's main enemy Harshavardhan of Kamrup. There is no reason to think that rulers of ancient India were religious fanatics and no evidence is provided by other credible sources. Bengal does not have any record of religious wars and Shashanka's main identity was that of an Aryan Khatriya.

After Shashanka there was a period of anarchy termed as Matsyanyam – again described as a tantric priest of Tibet- Lama Taranath- which was followed by the rise of Palas the first dynastic ruler of Bengal, one of the many Aryan chieftains who ruled over different parts of Bengal. The Pala were also Khatriya Aryans and were great protectors of Buddhism particularly Tantric Buddhism which was flourishing at that stage. To understand that a Khatriya Hindu ruler was patronizing Vajrayana/tantric Buddhism which was not a sworn enemy of Hinduism or a separate religion we also need to look at the resources and network of the Buddhist monasteries of that time which were dominantly Vajrayana in nature. Since this was the most organized network in Bengal, it's only natural the Pala's who had emerged from Matsanyam would seek the support of the vast monastic Buddhist network. There is no mention of the Palas converted from one religion to another as the idea and practice of conversion did not exist at that time.

However, that the Palas were not aware of any contesting power from Hindus is understood from large scale land grants made to Brahmins. So the Pala relationship with Buddhism and Hinduism is more political and practical than religious loyalty driven. They were also known as patrons of Nalanda University which sent forward to great Buddhist missionary Atish Dipankar and Padmasambhava to preach their faith outside Bengal. The Palas were replaced by the Senas- chieftains from Karnataka- who had initially supported

them after Matsanyam to become the kings of Bengal. So the rivalry of religions was obviously not there.

Once Senas came to power they immediately attacked the power infrastructure of the Pala's which were the Buddhist monastery and monks' network. Many Buddhist monks fled to Nepal and Tibet. This has been interpreted by some as religious persecution by caste Hinduism led by the Senas. However in those terms the religious identity of the Palas and the Sanas were the same and the Sana take over was not a religious but a political act.

The Senas upheld Hinduism as a contest of monastic Buddhism in political terms since the religious identity of ordinary people was vague and even theologically both were variants of the same faith. In matters of caste structure Bengalis had few Brahmin or Khatriya since there were no Aryans in the mixing races but of course some such settlements did grow up around Pundra. So, the question of communal harmony and disharmony does not arise in that era. This was a much later invention and became a problem only after British arrival when Hindu and Muslims belonging to the middle and upper class became rivals and became enemies in their pursuit of privileges given out by the British.

Hinduism and Buddhism were faiths that belonged to India but outside Bengal. The biggest external element in terms of extra Indian faith was Islam which came in an organized fashion after the establishment of the Turko- Afghan rule in India and Bakhtiar Khalji in Bengal. But there are no reports of any conversion forced or voluntary. The Turko-Afghan rulers were not religious missionaries but invaders setting up an empire who had no spiritual objectives. Overtime, particularly during the Sultani period in Bengal they tried to create an identity outside the imperial identity of Delhi which was also led by Turko-Afghan Muslims.

It was in search of a new social narrative that these rulers began to tolerate/ promote traditional cults and practices that were products of the many ethno-religious mixes. This led to tolerance and later promotion of Bhakti Cults. So the objective of promoting these cults was to create more supporters from the local population particularly in view of the military threat from Delhi. Like before no ruler interfered with the religious practice of the local people. The Madrassas that were established were not meant for spreading Islam but providing education of the Turko Afghan aristocracy children, far away from home.

Local deities also began to exert influence as the acceptance of non-Aryan practices saw an increase. An archetypal story is that the non-Aryan goddess Manasa manages to defeat Shiva, the Aryan deity. The case of Chand Sawdagar or a sea-trader who refuses to worship Manasa but in the end is forced to shows the rise of the trading community also.

\*\*\*\*\*

Soon after Mughals took Delhi major geographical and geological changes occurred in Bengal which opened up great agricultural opportunities due to the rise of new land and change of river routes. The Mughals became interested for the first time in the local people though as producers of wealth not as subjects. The state/ government at the top became linked to the villages at the bottom. This was possible because of agricultural projects.

The Mughal understood the values of new land and wet agriculture and expanding the economy. To achieve this they sent agriculture entrepreneurs also called Charismatics who began to organize the villages to produce more. The tool they used was religion/ mosque and people began to admire them as they were able to expand the livelihood space of ordinary people through agriculture.

Over time this admiration for the Charismatic agro-skills turned into admiration for their culture and practice as well and some began to identify themselves as Muslims though this was purely social. There was no theological transformation in this switch. They adopted only those elements of these agriculture specialists which did not conflict with their earlier belief. For example- they called the creator 'Niranjan' which is essentially a Hindu expression for the creator. It was impossible anyway to transfer Islamic theology to a people where the concept and idea and language of the Quran were totally missing. So the agro-leaders became known as Peer, Awliya or charismatics etc. The only significant social impact was probably in the practice of Muslims of not marrying non Muslim though we are not sure when this practice here began.

Islam was more like a layer on the earlier layer. So in summation we can state the following

1. Religion in Bengal is a product of mixing of many factor such as geography agriculture , migration of various community and introduction to various external culture in Bengal such as Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam.

2. The primary challenge in the life of a peasant was livelihoods so all faith practices are linked to that issue rather than any theological or philosophical matter. There was no religious structure or hierarchy.
3. Vedic Hinduism did not have any material basis for flourishing in Bengal since most people were agriculturist or fishermen who were linked to livelihood related faith practices. This is one reason why tantric Buddhism became popular as it was about controlling the uncontrollable using magic and mantra. These practical sides of tantric Buddhism appealed to Bengalis who were always challenged by nature and livelihood so the Bengali can be described as a follower of a mix of faith and practices like their ethnicity.